

What does that mean for us? It indicates that just because I might have poor self-control now doesn't mean I can't as an adult put in place mechanisms that mean I can adopt or improve self-control. Not unlike the children who used distractive techniques with the marshmallows.

Let me give an example of this from my own life where understanding my Financial Phenotype has helped me regulate my own lack of self-control.

Remember my food-related behaviour traits from the start of this book? One of my observable behaviour traits is my total lack of self-control when it comes to chocolate. I manage this behaviour with distracting techniques, rules and rewards, and strict rules around the type and amount of chocolate I allow in the house. In practice, this includes only buying certain brands of chocolate available from unique locations, gamifying my chocolate consumption based on when I exercise, and even recruiting others to keep me accountable if I'm having a detox from it. I've created behaviour to compensate for my lack of self-control and this system generally works beautifully for me. It means I can enjoy chocolate without overindulging or feeling guilty.

Similarly, when it comes to my financial behaviour, an observable behaviour I exhibit is low self-control around spending and saving. Again, I regulate this using distracting techniques, rules and reward, and managing my environment. And I make sure not to keep my savings in cash. This means having a small credit card limit and keeping my investments in businesses, shares, property and superannuation—places I'm not easily able or tempted to spend from. An example of my rules system is called a 'habit stack' (I'll talk about habit stacks when we get to Part Three): for every \$1 I spend on clothes and shoes, I have to invest \$1 in shares. This limits my spending and boosts my savings. Again, I've created behaviour to compensate for my lack of self-control, which limits my ability to sabotage my finances. It means present-me can enjoy today, while future-me is also looked after through the bespoke suite of habits I've adopted.

Now, it would have been easy to bemoan the fact that I should be able to financially adult and to constantly berate myself over my poor self-control. Or I could congratulate myself for recognising my unique Financial Phenotype and creating systems and techniques that work with my